



FROM A DEMOCRACY TO A DICTATORSHIP

THE NUREMBERG LAWS (1935)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Racial law

BEFORE

Mid-1800s In parts of northern Europe, a theory of Aryan racial purity develops: Jews, black people, and Slavs are deemed “racially inferior.”

1930 *The Myth of the Twentieth Century*, by Nazi Alfred Rosenberg, attempts philosophical justification for the persecution of the Jews.

AFTER

1938 In *Kristallnacht* (“the night of broken glass”), on November 9–10, anti-Jewish rioting is coordinated by paramilitaries across Germany; 30,000 Jews are arrested.

1939–1945 *Aktion T4* (the “T4 program”) authorizes some German physicians to carry out compulsory euthanasia of the deformed, disabled, and mentally ill.

Nazi racism toward Jewish people was apparent even before Adolf Hitler became chancellor in January 1933. Jews were seen as *Untermenschen* (“subhuman”), defiling racial purity. In the early 1930s, they were scapegoated and mistreated in an attempt to drive them out of Germany. Then, in 1935, the racial discrimination was made into law.

There were two Nuremberg Laws: the Law for the Protection of German Blood and German Honor, and the Reich Citizenship Law. They went much further than the many anti-Jewish decrees that had been passed since 1933, such as banning Jews from government positions and restricting their participation in key professions.

The German Blood and German Honor Law banned marriage between Jews and Germans, and “extramarital” relations were likewise outlawed. Jews could also no longer employ female Germans under 45 as domestic servants. The Citizenship Law gave a convoluted series of definitions of racial

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Everything we have done flows from the Nuremberg Laws.

Reinhard Heydrich

Nazi SS official
(1904–1942)

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identity. Those with one-eighth Jewish blood or less were deemed German and citizens of the Reich; those with three-quarters or entirely Jewish blood were stripped of all rights. Those in between were Reich citizens but not members of the German race.

The Nuremberg Laws were a key stepping stone to the Final Solution itself, authorized in 1941: Europe’s Jews were no longer merely to be victimized—they were to be exterminated. ■

See also: The Geneva Conventions 152–155 ■ The Nuremberg trials 202–209 ■ The Genocide Convention 210–211 ■ The Universal Declaration of Human Rights 222–229